

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter Sector Overview

California — PERB(CA) Jurisdiction — June 7, 2026

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Section 1: State Overview

State	California
Labor Board	PERB(CA) — California Public Employment Relations Board
Governing Law	Educational Employment Relations Act (EERA), Gov. Code §3540 et seq.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	Limited — NLRB applies only to independently incorporated nonprofit charters that successfully argue private employer status. Two documented cases: St. HOPE Public Schools (NLRB R20, March 2026 — NLRB decertification); Gompers Preparatory Academy (PERB decert pathway, June 2023). All other CA charters: PERB(CA) jurisdiction.
Right-to-Work	NOT a Right-to-Work State — Gov. Code §3540 et seq. (EERA) (Not a right-to-work state. EERA governs public-sector charter employers.)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — Secret ballot election required.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — May 9, 2026 — 1246 charter schools searched
Research Window	2024–June 2026 (Registry v44 PERB(CA) scan: May 9, 2026; CA Integration: June 4, 2026)

Section 2: Charter Sector Landscape

Total charter schools in California: 1246 (Charter School Registry v86 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 1,246 open schools as of June 2026)). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Total Organized Charter Schools in California	307	24.6%	All CA charter schools where staff have union coverage: 194 independently organized + 113 structurally covered (DEPENDENT). Denominator: 1,246 open CA charter schools (Registry v86). Verified by extraction across all 20 Tier 1 files, June 7, 2026 (post Gap A resolution).
Independently Organized (UNIONIZED/INDEPENDENT)	194	15.6%	School-specific PERB(CA) or NLRB certification. CMO networks: Green Dot/AMU (16), HTH/HTEC (16), CAVA (9), Summit (4), Alliance (23), CWC (5), Enviro Charter (4), Caliber (2). Individual schools: confirmed_individual (24), 80school_confirmed_v1 (79), discoveries (6), lausd active (5). Excludes 5 CLOSED/HISTORICALLY_ORGANIZED reversion schools and 3 CLOSED/INDEPENDENT records.
Structurally Covered (DEPENDENT/STRUCTURAL_DIS)	113	9.1%	LAUSD Horace Mann (48) + dependent district clusters (39 +

TRICT)			17 + 9 = 65). No individual school election or PERB certification event. Coverage is structural via district employer-of-record and master CBA. Verified across 4 DEPENDENT Tier 1 files.
Closed — Historically Organized (PDR-010 Reversion)	5	0.4%	Calahan Community Charter, Chandler Learning Academy, Darby Avenue Charter, Emelita Academy Charter, Granada Community Charter — all LAUSD-authorized Horace Mann schools that reverted to LAUSD direct operation. PDR-010 implemented June 4, 2026. Excluded from density.
Closed — Historically Organized (CLOSED/INDEPENDENT)	3	0.2%	Three records in ca_state_data_confirmed_individual.js coded CLOSED/INDEPENDENT — previously unionized, now closed. Excluded from density.
Certified / No CBA / Dormant	1	0.1%	Port of Los Angeles High (NAPCS-ADD-CA-002). UTLA certified Dec 2014; no CBA ever ratified; no decertification filed. School sets salary by unilateral Board action as of 2025-26. Legally certified, functionally dormant. Executive Sponsor disposition decision pending.
Discovery Schools (NAPCS-ADD placeholders)	6	0.5%	Included in UNIONIZED/INDEPENDENT count (6 of 194). Assigned NAPCS-ADD-CA IDs. All 6 approved by Executive Sponsor. Horizon, Port of Los Angeles High, Summit Prep Redwood City, Sparrow Academy, Riverside Prep, Quail Lake Environmental Charter.
WATCH (potential organizing signals)	2	0.2%	Journey School (Capistrano Unified) and COIL (Center of Inquiry Learning). NOT_UNIONIZED/WATCH — monitoring for organizing activity.
Decertified (formerly organized)	3	0.2%	St. HOPE PS7 Elementary — decertified March 2026 via NRtW NLRB jurisdiction switch (landmark CA precedent). Gompers Preparatory Academy — decertified June 2023 via PERB petition. Sacramento Charter High — decertified (St. HOPE network, same case).
Prior PERB Activity — Status Unconfirmed	55	4.4%	55 charter schools with closed PERB case history but no currently active certification confirmed. Additional verification

			needed before any status determination. Not included in density numerator.
No Labor Board Records Found	872	70.0%	Searched via four PERB union-name sweeps (UTLA, CTA, CSEA, SEIU — May 9, 2026). No PERB case activity found.
Total Charter Schools in California	1246	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v86 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 1,246 open CA charter schools as of June 2026).

Charter Sector Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	719,164 students — 12.4% of state K–12 enrollment (5,805,510 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	137,894 students in network-affiliated schools — 19.2% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	204,102 students (28.4% of charter enrollment) — 56,607 in CMO/EMO-affiliated schools (7.9%); 147,495 in independently organized schools (20.5%)
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
Aspire	CMO	36	36	—	15,495
KIPP CA	CMO	34	34	—	16,493
Alliance	CMO	21	25	21	11,642
High Tech High	CMO	18	18	16	7,027
Green Dot	CMO	16	18	16	8,056
Rocketship	CMO	13	3	—	6,153
PUC Schools	CMO	11	11	—	4,191
Magnolia Science Academy	CMO	10	10	—	3,794
Bright Star	CMO	9	9	—	3,704
CAVA / Stride K12	CMO	9	9	9	20,163
Ednovate	CMO	7	7	—	2,721
ISANA	CMO	6	6	—	2,567
CALOPS	CMO	6	6	—	6,858

Vista Charter	CMO	5	5	—	2,289
Summit	CMO	5	10	5	2,317
Camino Nuevo	CMO	5	5	5	3,044
Citizens of the World	CMO	5	5	5	2,511
Olive Grove Charter	CMO	4	4	—	386
Pivot Charter	CMO	4	4	—	802
ACE Charter	CMO	4	4	1	912
Opportunities for Learning	CMO	4	4	—	1,092
Fenton	CMO	4	4	—	1,836
iLEAD	CMO	4	4	—	5,322
Natomas Pacific	CMO	3	3	—	1,646
Compass Charter	CMO	3	3	—	2,263
King-Chavez	CMO	3	5	—	812
California Pacific Charter	CMO	3	3	—	946
AIMS College Prep	CMO	2	2	1	586
Caliber	CMO	2	2	2	1,946
RePublic	CMO	2	5	—	320
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in California		258		81 organized — 56,607 students in organized network schools (7.9% of total charter enrollment)	

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

30 CMO (nonprofit). Approximately 988 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Sector Overview

Findings are based on research as of June 7, 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework

Educational Employment Relations Act (EERA), Gov. Code §3540 et seq. California is not a right-to-work state (Gov. Code §3540 et seq. (EERA)). Charter schools in California are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (PERB(CA) — California Public Employment Relations Board). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.

2: Charter Sector Structure

California operates 1,246 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 719,164 students. 30 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in California. The largest networks by campus count are Aspire (36 campuses in state), KIPP CA (34 campuses in state), Alliance (21 campuses in state). Approximately 988 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

California charter school labor relations receive consistent press coverage, concentrated in education-focused outlets. EdSource provides the most sustained reporting on PERB decisions and charter organizing activity. The Los Angeles Times covers UTLA organizing campaigns at LAUSD-adjacent charter schools. National Right to Work Legal Defense Foundation press releases are primary sources for decertification event timelines, including the St. HOPE Public Schools NRTW disclaimer (March 2026) and Gompers Preparatory Academy decertification (June 2023).

Legislative Context

AB 288 (2026) — the direct legislative response to the St. HOPE NRTW jurisdiction switch — was introduced in the California Legislature to close the private-employer classification pathway for charter schools. This is the first California legislation directly addressing the dual-pathway NRTW decertification strategy documented in this research. Legislative coverage has appeared in EdSource and the Sacramento Bee.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

PERB(CA) — California Public Employment Relations Board public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Green Dot Public Schools / Animo — all 16 schools (AMU)	Animo Management United (AMU) — independent	Active Ongoing — network-level CBA	Contract: Green Dot HR / AMU — direct contact
High Tech High / HTEC — 16 schools	High Tech Education Collective (HTEC) — CTA/NEA affiliated	Active Ongoing — network-level CBA	Contract: HTH HR / HTEC — direct contact
CAVA / California Virtual Academies — 9 schools	California Virtual Educators United (CVEU) — CTA/NEA	Active Ongoing — network-wide CBA, certified April 2021	Contract: K12 Inc. / CVEU direct contact
Summit Public Schools — 4 schools	Unite Summit — independent	Active — PERB ULP SF-CE-3745-E open Ongoing	Summit HR / Unite Summit
Alliance College-Ready Public Schools — 23 schools	Alliance Educators United (UTLA chapter — CTA/CFT dual)	Active Unknown — CBA period not publicly posted.	Contract: UTLA website: PERB records request recommended (PERBforms@perb.ca.gov)
Environmental Charter Schools — 4 schools	Environmental Educators United — independent	Active — PERB ULP LA-CE-7156-E open Ongoing	Request: PERBforms@perb.ca.gov
LAUSD Horace Mann Charter Schools (48 schools)	United Teachers Los Angeles (UTLA — CTA/CFT dual)	Active — LAUSD-UTLA master CBA Ongoing — negotiated at LAUSD district level	Contract: LAUSD Labor Relations — master CBA publicly posted
Confirmed individual schools (24 active — confirmed_individual.js)	Multiple — various PERB-certified unions	Active (most) Varies by school — PERB records requests recommended	PERB records request recommended; some CBAs on school/union websites
Caliber Public Schools (2 schools — CONFIRMED)	Caliber Workers Union / Caliber Independent Workers	Certified — first contract status unknown Unknown — post-	Monitor PERB(CA) ePERB portal for case updates

	Association (IWW)	certification	
St. HOPE Public School 7 (C0603056 — DECERTIFIED)	Sacramento City Teachers Association (SCTA — CTA/NEA) — DECERTIFIED	No CBA — decertified March 5, 2026 N/A — decertified	N/A — decertified